UNIT 7

The Guptas

Learning Objectives

- To learn the importance of Guptas rule in Indian history.
- To understand the significance of land grants and its impact on agricultural economy of the empire.
- To acquaint ourselves with the nature of the society and the socio-economic life of the people of the time.
- To know the development of culture, art and education during the period.

Introduction

After the Mauryan empire, many small kingdoms rose and fell. In the period from c. 300 to 700 CE, a classical pattern of an imperial rule evolved, paving the way for state formation in many regions. During this period, the Gupta kingdom emerged as a great power and achieved the political unification of a large part of the Indian subcontinent. It featured a strong central government, bringing many kingdoms under its hegemony. Feudalism as an institution began to take root during this period. With an effective guild system and overseas trade, the Gupta economy boomed. Great works in Sanskrit were produced during this period and a high level of cultural maturity in fine arts, sculpture and architecture was achieved.

The living standards of upper classes reached a peak. Education, art and study of science progressed, but the feudal system of governance put people in some form of hardship. Although some historians proclaim that Gupta period was a golden age, it is not entirely accurate. Many scholars would, however, agree that it was a period of cultural florescence and a classical age for the arts.

Sources

There are three types of sources for reconstructing the history of the Gupta period.

I. Literary sources

- Narada, Vishnu, Brihaspati and Katyayana smritis.
- Kamandaka's *Nitisara*, a work on polity addressed to the king (400 CE)
- *Devichandraguptam* and *Mudrarakshasam* by Vishakadutta provide details about the rise of the Guptas.
- Buddhist and Jaina texts
- Works of Kalidasa
- Accounts of the Chinese traveller Fahien

II. Epigraphical Sources

- Mehrauli Iron Pillar inscription – achievements of Chandragupta I.
- Allahabad Pillar inscription – describing Samudragupta's personality and achievements in 33 lines composed by Harisena and engraved in Sanskrit and in Nagari script.



Mehrauli Iron Pillar

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